

Small town dreams

Youth in small towns think exactly like their metro counterparts



Youth from mini-metros spend more on food and household items (17.3% of income), eating out (14.8%) and clothes (13.9%).

65% of small town youth do not access the Internet. When they do log on to the Web, it's for information.

21% of small town women think good looks are most important in choosing a spouse

53% of small town men are open to marrying working women. Almost 60% are open to the idea of divorce.

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63% men chat with strangers online, while women are less adventurous, with only **39%** doing so.

METHODOLOGY

The focus of this year's youth survey, the fourth by INDIA TODAY-AC Nielsen-ORG-MARG, was to understand the world of relationships around today's young men and women. The young person's interaction with spouse/partner, friends, parents, extended family and colleagues was investigated. For this purpose, 2,857 interviews were conducted amongst youth aged 16-30 years in the socio-economic categories A, B and C. The number of male respondents was 1,463 and that of female respondents was 1,394; 1,438 were unmarried and 1,419 were married. The fieldwork for the study was done in the first three weeks of January. A street corner sampling technique was followed for the purpose of this survey, which is why the response to questions on smoking, drinking, drugs and pre-marital sex was conservative as expected. In the previous sex survey, when a secret ballot method was followed, 30 per cent in the age group of 21-30 admitted to having had pre-marital sex, whereas this survey has shown only 10 per cent admitting the same. The responses on smoking and drinking were also muted.

cent do so at school/college/tuitions and only 16 and 12 per cent do so at restaurants and shopping malls, respectively. Greater mixing of the sexes also leads to a more pragmatic attitude towards marriage—42 per cent emphatically believe divorce is better than a bad marriage.

So while men have come to accept working women as their due (54 per cent say they would prefer to marry a working woman), they give her a role in financial decisions only when she brings home a pay cheque. What's more, 33 per cent of the men believe they are being gracious when they say they will allow the woman to decide if she wants to give up her career after marriage. Men with working wives tend to rely more on friends and colleagues for personal support, probably an instance of emotional infidelity. Husbands of working women also chat online more with strangers and watch more action films.

Have the young women lost their fetters or gained a new set—sleeker, less visible, but no less strong? In the answer lies the future of a more equitable relationship between men and women. That will only happen when the emerging woman is met halfway by the new man. A little more self-esteem from the young woman and a little less self-regard from the young man would do the trick.

with Chitra Subramanyam, Bushra Ahmed and Purvi Malhotra